



FIRST-TIME HOMEBUYER GUIDE



Buying your first home? Start here.

You don't need to know everything before you begin. You just need a clear plan and the right people guiding you.

1. Know Your Budget

Before looking at homes, understand what monthly payment feels comfortable for you.

Consider more than just the purchase price:

- ☐ Mortgage payment
- ☐ Property taxes
- ☐ Homeowners insurance
- ☐ HOA fees, if applicable
- ☐ Utilities and maintenance

Tip: What you qualify for and what you're comfortable paying may be two different numbers.

2. Get Pre-Approved

Talk with a licensed mortgage professional before seriously shopping for homes.

Your lender may review:

- ☐ Income
- ☐ Credit history
- ☐ Monthly debts
- ☐ Assets and savings
- ☐ Employment information

A pre-approval can help you understand your buying power and strengthen your offer.

3. Prepare Your Savings

Your down payment isn't the only expense to plan for.

You may also need funds for:

- ☐ Earnest money
- ☐ Home inspection
- ☐ Appraisal
- ☐ Closing costs
- ☐ Moving expenses
- ☐ Emergency savings

Ask your lender for an estimated cash-to-close amount.





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4. Build Your Home Wishlist

Separate your must-haves from your nice-to-haves.

Think about:

- ☐ Location
- ☐ Number of bedrooms and bathrooms
- ☐ Commute
- ☐ Lot size
- ☐ HOA or no HOA
- ☐ New construction vs. resale
- ☐ Future plans

This makes your home search much more focused.

5. Start Touring Homes

When you find a home you like, look beyond the finishes.

Pay attention to:

- ☐ Overall condition
- ☐ Neighborhood
- ☐ Layout
- ☐ Major systems
- ☐ Potential repairs
- ☐ HOA rules and fees
- ☐ Resale considerations

Take photos and notes. Homes can start blending together after several showings.

6. Make an Offer

Your real estate agent can help you review:

- ☐ Comparable home sales
- ☐ Asking price
- ☐ Competition
- ☐ Earnest money
- ☐ Contingencies
- ☐ Seller credits or concessions
- ☐ Closing timeline

A strong offer isn't always just the highest price.





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7. Complete Your Due Diligence

Once your offer is accepted, the real work begins.

Depending on your transaction, this may include:

- ☐ Home inspection
- ☐ Reviewing disclosures
- ☐ Appraisal
- ☐ Loan underwriting
- ☐ Homeowners insurance
- ☐ HOA document review
- ☐ Final loan approval

Ask questions anytime something doesn't make sense.

8. Get Ready for Closing

Before signing:

- ☐ Review your final documents
- ☐ Confirm your cash needed to close
- ☐ Complete your final walkthrough
- ☐ Confirm utilities
- ☐ Avoid major financial changes before closing

Then comes the best part.

 **GET THE KEYS!**

Disclaimer: This guide is for general educational and informational purposes only and is not intended as legal, tax, financial, or lending advice. Financing requirements, costs, programs, timelines, and real estate procedures vary by buyer, lender, property, and transaction. Consult the appropriate licensed professionals for guidance specific to your situation.



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